

# states ANDHRA PRADESH

**TDP is in for a triple-whammy: rising rebellion, the near collapse of the Third Front and emergence of Chiranjeevi's political party signal a bumpy ride ahead**

■ By Amarnath K. Menon

**T**he year is turning out to be one of the worst for Telugu Desam Party (TDP) chief N. Chandrababu Naidu. Even as he hears news of his one-time ally, the Samajwadi Party (SP) deserting the Third Front to support the Congress on Indo-US nuclear deal, his party is facing its worst existential crisis in 26 years. A number of second-rung leaders have revolted against his leadership and resigned from the party. K. Vidhyadhar Rao, former industries minister, was the first to be expelled on charges of going against the party discipline and proclaiming support for filmstar Chiranjeevi's yet-to-be-launched political outfit.

However, the big shock came when T. Devender Goud, the No. 2 in the party and a former home minister, left the TDP in June to launch his own pro-Telangana outfit. "The TDP had lost its shape and base. What could I do when there was such a wide gap between the party and people," asked Goud, who is a staunch supporter of the Telangana cause. He has been able to garner a lot of support and many TDP members from the region are poised to join him. He even went on to declare, "Time has come to launch a second freedom struggle to achieve statehood for Telangana which has suffered neglect and discrimination for several decades. Ours will be a peaceful Gandhian movement making the weaker sections partners in the process." The Telangana issue, which had dominated the last assembly elections and seen the rise of the Telangana Rashtriya Samithi, had earlier been relegated to the background by the UPA Government despite the promise in the common minimum programme to set up a



## WHEEL OF MISF

state reorganisation panel on the issue.

In fact, Goud's exit seems to have opened the floodgates with fresh shock waves coming from the Rayalseema region in the form of resignations by B. Nagi Reddy, a former MP, and his wife Sobha, a party general secretary. They alleged that Naidu had been ignoring sincere party workers. "The TDP under Naidu has failed to live up to the expectations of the workers," said

Nagi Reddy, even as the man under fire was heard retorting, "The TDP gave a lot to his family. I made him MP and his wife an MLA. If one wants to leave the party, they may go but it is not proper to level such allegations."

Next, it was the turn of two more senior leaders to quit the

party in disgust—former law minister Narse Goud and Kadapa district general secretary S.A. Khaleel Basha. Both of them harboured grudges against Naidu and held him singularly responsible for TDP's ruin. "Naidu does not even have the benevolence of a dictator and is singularly responsible for the ruin of the party," said Narse Goud.

Though most of these leaders are preparing to jump on to Chiranjeevi's soon-to-be-launched party, what is significant is that most of them have left the TDP due to Naidu's alleged foibles and failures. But putting up a brave front, former finance minister Yanamala Ramakrishnudu claimed that the party was not worried about the exodus, nor would it suffer and in fact, the loss—both political and personal—would be of those who have left the TDP. "Chiranjeevi is a film artiste. He may start a party and over-ambitious people may join him, but our party is still intact. The

**Naidu is now toying with the idea of shifting his party's earlier stand on a samayika or united Andhra Pradesh.**